

20210303 – Ogwo – Pt. 2

Tobar: We are recording. And this is Part 2 of Interview with Ashley Ogwo. And it is March 3, 2021. I think that the first place to start if you feel OK with it is sort of give me a sense of what your first memories were as an entering student to Teacher's College and thinking about that part of your journey. And you could start anywhere you like.

Ogwo: [00:00:32] Yeah, so, it feels like a while ago. I think coming into TC I was excited. As I mentioned, before, I was really feeling like TC was definitely an academic home for me and it felt like a great match for where I was. And just a great way for me to continue building along my journey. And so I was excited to come in and get a chance to kind of learn with and from these faculty members that really made an impression on me during Admitted Student's Day. And so was just very happy to kind of jump in.

[00:01:17] I think with everything there is a little bit of kind of the nerves of going back to school and whatnot. But it was very much and very easily kind of mitigated because of the openness of our faculty and learning with the other students, getting a chance to meet the other students. Particularly getting a chance to reconnect with those that I had seen at the preview, the Admitted Students Day, and then kind of coming in and getting a chance to learn more with them.

Tobar: Great. How did your identity affect your day-to-day experience when you were a student and TC? Do you feel that this was a marginalized identity as you were an incoming student?

Ogwo: [00:02:08] I would say I think my identity impacts – particularly my racial identity – impacts any space that I walk into. So I'm always aware of my blackness in any space that I occupy and so TC was no exception. I think that in terms of my day-to-day I was very fortunate to be in classroom spaces when I was on campus that were considerate of my racial identity, which I do consider a minoritized identity.

[00:02:48] And I think that because my faculty were aware of racial issues, as well as oppression that's placed on racially minoritized individuals, I think that it very much showed up within the teaching. And so I did not have to be concerned about further harm being perpetuated on me as a black person within my classroom space from my faculty, those who were instructing me.

[00:03:20] And I could say the same for just in general walking around TC I think that I had the opportunity to connect with various individuals from staff to the security guards to other students. And so I don't think I felt – I don't think I felt as much racial concern in terms of my safety as I could have within another space. But I think a lot of that has to do with the fact that my program was very open and honest about combating racial issues, aware of how those racial issues are systemic and ingrained within our

system, even within TC. And so that allowed me to walk with a lot more confidence around just kind of my positioning at TC.

Tobar: And broadly speaking, how do you believe your race affected your own classroom experience at Teacher's College and did it ever feel isolating?

Ogwo: [00:04:37] I don't think it felt isolating. But, again, I would say that is because of my program. I was very fortunate that my program was very understanding of racial issues. Very open, honest, and just kind of straight to the point about the fact that we live in a racist society and our society functions on racism. And so they were very aware of that fact and made it known to other students.

[00:05:10] So I never felt like my classroom experiences were isolating because my professors made those points very clear. And they would argue any point that someone would even try to make if they had some type of inclination to make regarding a racially minoritized group that was offensive or problematic in any way. They were very quick to not necessarily just shut that person down, but to talk about why those lines of thinking are incorrect, are harmful, and perpetuate a narrative of deficit for minoritized individuals.

[00:05:48] So, again, my experience was very positive within my academic sphere, within the classroom. I cannot say the same for other individuals I know that were outside of my program. And so while there were folks who had to be concerned about harm being perpetuated on them within the classroom space, be concerned about their faculty saying things like the "n" word, being concerned about their faculty not understanding the racial harm that the classroom space can do particularly for black students in a predominantly white environment.

[00:06:24] I never heard those concerns because my faculty made those things very clear and made them very noticeable for students that "I'm not an expert on these things. I have some knowledge, but you by virtue of your lived experiences will know more than me and that is OK. But let me know what I can do to help in terms of ensuring that you are not taking on any burden that you don't want to in trying to educate other students."

[00:06:58] I remember having Katie, Dr. Conway, come up to me after a class in which a white student had said something along the lines of insinuating that stereotype threat – from Dr. Claude Steele – could have been the result of the individual just feeling like they weren't good enough and maybe it was just the individual and not tied to the system or the society.

[00:07:31] And so I remember responding to that and just explaining why that's incorrect and why the perpetuation of that narrative of individualism is why we're in the place that we are. And so then afterwards she came up to me after class and said, you know, "I just wanted to check in, see how you were doing, and I also wanted to let you know that while you are –

I'm more than happy to have you respond to students who make comments like that, I don't want you to feel that you have to."

[00:08:06] And so she wanted to check in with me on that front. And I very much – and I thanked her for it because I appreciated the care that she showed with that and the understanding that she showed in knowing that black students oftentimes have to bear that burden of educating their classmates on racial issues, even if they don't want to because they're seen as a spokesperson for their race.

Tobar: Thank you for that. I guess the next question I have is do you believe faculty and students at TC value diversity? Why or why not? And do they provide support and what kind? And you did a great job with the previous question illustrating how HPSE faculty member was able to do that. And I'm wondering if you have anything to share about other professors or whether folks outside of the program also showed that same level of support that you may have encountered during your time at TC?

Ogwo: [00:09:02] I would say a lot of people value diversity. It's the equity part that I think is very different. So I would say 1) TC part of I'm sure their goals is to increase diversity at the institution. But increasing diversity is not enough. You have to make sure that once the students actually get there, they're supported. And understanding that there are differences in how those students are impacted, what their experiences look like based on different factors and facets of their identity.

[00:09:39] And so I think there are a lot of people who value diversity at TC. I definitely think faculty members value diversity. Not all, but quite a few. But in practice that might look different. So, again, when we're getting into diversity to me it can feel very performative when there's not action accompanied with that.

[00:10:08] And so I would say one example of both diversity and equity being valued within the classroom space outside of HPSE was when I had the opportunity to take class with Dr. Yolonda Sealey-Ruiz. And so she just – taking the class with her – and it was a class in which there were mostly preservice teachers. And so having the opportunity to kind of learn with and from those students and understanding that there were white, black, brown, all types of races, students within that classroom and for a lot of these students who were preservice teachers, they were going into spaces that looked black and brown around the city.

[00:11:03] And so she did a great job of emphasizing and illustrating the fact that students are coming in from different points in their racial journeys and that impacts how they engage, but moreso that impacts how they engage with their students as a preservice teacher. And so she made several assignments, discussions, just kind of thoughts around how to come to understand your racial and ethnic development, what that means for you and then, also, what that means for your students and how you engage with them, how you interact with them.

[00:11:50] And so, again, emphasizing this fact that, yes, diversity is important, and it's valuable, but also that equity mindset is just as important. Understanding that students may be coming from a different lens, but that does not make them less than or less understanding of the content that you're teaching. They are just having a different way of understanding the concepts. And that is also powerful.

[00:12:21] So they bring other identities to the table that enhance your work as a teacher. And so it was very much that diversity lens, but also understanding that there was – I don't want to use too many theories, but also understanding, you know, community cultural wealth. Also understanding kind of equitable practice and what that looks like for teachers. So a lot of opportunities to explore those facets within her class.

Tobar: Thank you for that. What barriers exist that prevent TC, you believe, from leveraging differences and being inclusive of all students.

Ogwo: [00:13:04] This is a hard question because I believe the barriers, while they exist at TC, they're also reflective of larger societal barriers. And so I cannot separate the institutional barriers that TC has from the larger societal barriers facing, for me, black people.

[00:13:31] I think that part of the barrier issue is actually understanding the diversity within groups of students. So not looking at or painting students with a broad brush. So understanding that there's a lot of diversity even within black groups, right. You don't just have black American, black African, black Caribbean populations. You have a mix of these folks coming from a host of different backgrounds, ethnically, class-wise.

[00:14:07] And so understanding that the intersection of these various identities help to make your institution more diverse and robust, but you also have to put in that much more work to make sure that these students feel supported. And so I think that part of the issue is if you are not willing to see students as individuals and see that their cultures, their identities demand representation and understanding on your part for the institution.

[00:14:47] You're always going to be at a loss if you're not able to find ways to ensure that students feel supported. Whether that's through frequently checking in, and then not being afraid to make changes based on those check-ins – whether those are through surveys, interviews, focus groups, however you do it. Just being unafraid of change and being unafraid of criticism.

[00:15:11] So I think that part of being human is not wanting to face criticism and we double that or even triple that when we're talking about institutions because they are wanting to be painted in the best light that they can. And so I think that sometimes when individuals challenge or pushback or criticize institutions, their first response is to defend or become defensive, and that's a barrier.

[00:15:44] If you're not open to receiving what students are saying about your institution – and not just students, staff, faculty, all the various stakeholders. If you're not open to hearing what they have to say about making the environment better, then you're a part of the problem. Because the reason that they're bringing this up is because they care. And so in bettering the institution or to be more inclusive of all students, you need to actually hear what these students are bringing forth to the table. Not just the good things, but also the bad things and how can we work to improve those bad things and make those into the good things about this institution.

Tobar: Broadly speaking, how would you believe your race affects your own ability – or how your race affected your own ability to succeed at TC, if at all, while you were there as a student?

Ogwo: [00:16:44] I think that in terms of my ability to succeed, I do not separate my abilities from my blackness. All of those are just my intersectional identities. And so I can't say I succeeded because of or in spite of or whatever. I can just say that I succeeded because of the people that were around me and because they acknowledged my full self, which includes my blackness.

[00:17:22] And so I don't think that I would say my racial identity hindered my accomplishments or achievements or ability to achieve in the same sense that one might get at – even within another program at TC. So because of the fact that I did not have to be afraid of the spaces that I occupied academically within my program, and I did not have to be afraid in the sense of racial safety – because I did not have to worry about that, I think that my achievement or accomplishment or abilities were allowed to shine.

[00:18:22] And so, yeah, I don't separate my ability to succeed from my blackness, but I will say that the fact that I was not worried about my physical safety within the space also plays a role in my ability to succeed. Because I know that – I'm aware of the burden that being in harmful spaces, being in traumatic spaces, can have on not just students' mental or physical or academic abilities, but also kind of their emotional capabilities, what they're able to bring to conversations, to doing work.

[00:19:01] And so I understand those traumas can be exhausting metabolically on students. And so that impacts how we're able to do our work. And so understanding that that is something to keep in mind, I was very fortunate to not have to worry about those things because of, again, the understanding of my faculty and their ability to create these braver spaces for students of color.

Tobar: I feel like this would be a good transition to you speaking about your initial involvement with Black Lives Matter Higher Education. What do you recall about first being involved and how it affected you at the time?

Ogwo: [00:19:47] Yeah. I first got involved I think – so I went to a couple of the events. I knew Cha and Brian and Kat just from classes that we took, from being around the program, and then also through Corbin and Noah, of course. And so when they had invited us to some of their events I was like – I thought it was a great opportunity to learn more about whatever the topic of the event was.

[00:20:27] And so I can't remember the – oh, the first event that I went to was – this was right after the white supremacists were marching on UVA's campus. And so having that discussion it was just very fruitful, it was very engaging how they framed it. And so that was kind of my first look into the group.

[00:21:00] And then afterwards, I went to another event that they had which was directly related to my research interests. And so I was very excited to go because they had Dr. Chrystal George Mwangi speaking as a guest. And so getting a chance to learn from and hear from her was amazing. And then, afterwards, they kind of approached us and said, "Hey, would you be interested in kind of joining the group as we put on events and doing the event planning and kind of creating these concepts and implementing them?"

[00:21:41] And so we were very excited to kind of get started. I joined at the same time that Jenay was joining and so getting a chance to do that with someone that I knew and then getting a chance to kind of get involved in work that I felt was important was very exciting.

Tobar: That's so great. I would love to learn more about the topic of research interest that you were really compelled to listen and learn more about if you can recall that. And if you could recall what year that was – your first year of involvement.

Ogwo: [00:22:16] So I want to say that was 20 – maybe late 2017 or early 2018. I'm saying this in terms of academic years. Not the calendar year. So either the spring semester of 2017 or the fall semester – or going into the fall semester of 2018. I want to say probably closer to spring semester of 2017. And when I was attending those events, yes, that was – I believe I attended one in the fall and then the other one was within the spring.

[00:23:06] I want to say – yeah. The event was – oh, gosh. It might have honestly been in like late fall or early spring. Either way, I know that 2017 was really when I kind of got to know more about BLMHE. And so the events that really sparked me – well, not sparked my research interest, but I kind of took as opportunity to learn more about my research interests was looking at – I believe that event was called All Black Lives Matter in Higher Ed.

[00:23:51] And it really looked at the various – what I talked about earlier about the various populations within the black diaspora. So understanding that there are multiple understandings and expressions of blackness across

the black diaspora. So she brought in those components of discussing Caribbean populations, discussing African populations.

[00:24:21] And how within the US these populations are considered black. And so that kind of label or same race label that everyone is getting kind of – if that aligns with the expressions of, let's say international or immigrant populations. And she talked a little bit about that. Just kind of coming to understand what race means within an American context and how students who were just coming from another country, whether that was a country they were born in or were just immigrating from, they had to learn race within an American context.

[00:25:10] And so understanding what black means in an American context is very different if you grew up in a predominantly black country and did not necessarily have to think about your race in that sense the same way you would within an American context. And so she talked about that and just talked about various understandings of blackness.

[00:25:34] She briefly touched on around the world. One of the things that she mentioned was the – how within the UK in a time of resistance, folks kind of identified, even if you weren't racially black, you identified as black as a part of this kind of political or justice-oriented movement.

[00:26:01] And so kind of talking about blackness in all of its facets and what and how we should continue to support and show up for black students as they are within the academy and within higher education. It was very much aligned with my research interests, which are around exactly that. Kind of the relationships and dynamics across various black ethnic groups and then, also, looking at black expression and identity across the African diaspora.

[00:26:37] And so it was very much aligned with what I wanted to do and am doing now.

Tobar: Thank you for that. Can you describe what your vision of activism was before becoming involved with BLMHE and how has that vision and your role within that different vision of activism changed since then?

Ogwo: [00:26:57] Yeah. So, before I got involved with BLMHE, my vision of activism was very much those – kind of what you see on the news. Those folks who are on the frontlines who have megaphones, or who are attending sit-ins or a part of protests. The individuals who are holding up the signs and everything. That, for me, was my understanding of activism. Just kind of being where the action is, physically.

[00:27:33] And then it was when I started learning more about BLMHE's mission and then also talking with Brian, with Kat, with Cha about kind of what it means to be an activist within a higher education space. And how writing and research and kind of theory can also be used to push back and

question systems and write student stories or black people's stories into existence – into literary existence and research existence.

[00:28:22] So that, for me, grew or expanded my definition or understanding of activism to include written works. To include research. To include these things that were, when they were created were stereotypically associated with white people and white bodies. And so being able to understand how research can be used to, again, question these systems. To push back against these systems.

[00:28:53] To create counter-narratives. To uplift black voices, and to make sure that black voices are heard within academic spaces. It helped to expand that definition to include those types of activism. So not just on the frontlines in terms of my physical body, but also being able to – if I wasn't able to engage in that way, being able to engage within classroom discourse, or within research that I was reading, or question research that I was reading.

[00:29:26] Build on theory. Point out the flaws in theory. Point out the white centering within theory. Just being able to do all these different facets and consider them as activism, as well.

Tobar: Thank you. Could you describe a little bit about that time period and what followed in your own development as a student and aspiring academic and higher education practitioner with your time spent at BLMHE. And could you give me some examples that come to mind?

Ogwo: [00:30:00] I'm going to ask you to repeat your question so I can hear each part of it.

Tobar: Sure. Just describing what your involvement was like during that time period. So you're onboard, you've just been recruited. What was that like and what followed and how did that affect or impact your development as a student of higher education, as an academic or aspiring higher education practitioner?

Ogwo: [00:30:26] So, I think as soon as we kind of got recruited it was starting to think through, "so, what events do you all want to put on? What are your interests? What do you feel like is needed on this campus that we can do and promote through our events?" And so it was an exciting time to just kind of get ideas out there to think through, "OK, what would I want to see in practice?" What that process would look like, what the implementation would look like.

[00:31:04] Yeah, it was just kind of a time in which we were doing a lot of kind of thinking and there was a lot of kind of enthusiasm around just various ideas and getting a chance to kind of connect and learn more about the people who were in the organization with me. And so it was a very like – I keep saying "exciting" again.

[00:31:29] It was just a very interesting time to be within that space. To kind of get to put all of those ideas and thoughts to action, or to a space in which we could present them through events or through advertising and things like that. So, I very much enjoyed kind of that onboarding process and getting to kind of jump right in with planning and brainstorming and things like that.

[00:32:04] Yeah, I think another exciting part for me was just kind of getting to hear from other folks. We had a couple of meetings with Students for Quality Education and so while an event – or a collaboration between the two of us never panned out, but just even getting a chance to sit down with one of their members and just kind of like talking, chatting about just how our institutions can do better and what we can do as organizations to kind of increase the voices, uplift the voices of black students on not just TC's campus but the larger Columbia University.

[00:32:56] And so it was a very – it was a great time to be a part of BLMHE.

Tobar: I'm going to shift more towards like now your internal journey as a graduate student while – where you were at at BLMHE. What goal did you have in mind to accomplish while you're were at TC and how has a degree from TC helped you?

Ogwo: [00:33:21] My goal was always to kind of go to the next level. To take my learning and my understanding, my education to the next level. And so I never saw myself kind of stopping with a master's degree from TC. I felt like I wanted and needed to do more to understand more about the communities that I was interested in. My communities.

[00:33:52] And so I felt that in trying to achieve that goal I made sure to talk to various people. Talk to professors. Talk to staff members. Talk to other students. Even talk to just people who would listen, you know? Because I think part of what we miss sometimes in our hustle and bustle is those interactions with people who folks might not take the time to interact with.

[00:34:28] And so, for example, I used to talk all the time with the security guards. And they were from a host of different countries. Countries that I was interested in. And so they fit within those populations I was interested in learning more about. So we had security guard from Ghana. We had a security guard from Liberia. And so talking with these folks and obviously my background as a Nigerian American, talking to these folks about their experiences, both before and after coming to this country.

[00:35:04] It kind of just reemphasized my goal of learning more about the black diasporic populations I was interested in exploring. And so it very much excited me. It made me, you know, more and more willing to explore my passions and seeing the need to delve into some of these topics I had been talking about pretty much my entire life.

[00:35:35] And so I think my time at TC and my goal of just learning more, it helped to kind of shape my outlook, but also my experience because I was actively seeking out these conversations, seeking out just connecting with other people.

[00:35:59] And then, afterwards, just being able to have these conversations. Even if I wasn't actively able to apply them to an academic experience or to a research opportunity or something like that, it was still an opportunity to see and reinforce the importance of exploring the diversity across the black diaspora. So even just getting a chance to sit and talk with – or as they're passing kind of chat with not just security guards but also our like custodial staff and things like that.

[00:36:38] Because they were also from various places, countries within the Caribbean. And so it was just a great opportunity to kind of like sit and reflect on just the diversity and stories that need to be told within and across the black diaspora and about the black diaspora.

Tobar: Thank you for that. I feel like the next question sort of taps into already that. How were you able to tap into your strengths and talents? I'm just perceiving right now your interpersonal nature is a strength, right? You had a talent for that and you tapped into it in order to help achieve your goals. Were there any other strengths and talents that you dug deep into to help achieve your goals at that time? That helped you meet your goals?

Ogwo: [00:37:29] I think because I'm very determined to get what I need to get done – done and done well. And I say that is a talent because sometimes you have to be stubborn in order to make sure that you get to your goal. And so you need to have – I wouldn't say a one-track focus because life gets in the way, sometimes. But you have to have that determination to continue to pursue what it is that you're pursuing, whatever that goal or whatever those goals look like.

[00:38:09] You have to have that determination and sometimes that stubbornness to say, no, despite whatever is on the left or on the right, I'm going to continue on this path that I set forth for myself. And I think that that was a huge strength for me being able to – even in the midst of, you know, it being just an academic challenge to continue pursuing my master's degree. Not being deterred by that process, or the difficulty, or taking multiple classes and trying to balance, you know, multiple deadlines or close deadlines.

[00:38:48] Balancing that with work obligations. And so I think that focus, that determination and a little bit of stubbornness that I had around getting to my goals were very much helpful and instrumental in me achieving them. And then obviously – you already touched on it – but just my interpersonal nature is very much a strength and so I tapped into that a lot. Making sure that I made connections and built connections with folks within different facets, especially because they were helpful in me kind of

learning more about other institutions, other avenues to take a higher education degree in.

[00:39:35] And so being able to kind of connect with people on different levels and in different facets was helpful for me to kind of get to where I need to be but also to soften certain blows. For example, me being friends with folks who were on staff and things like that had some benefits because then if I – let's say I left something while I was studying and they knew me and they knew, OK, this might be hers, like I could go up to them and say, "Hey, have you heard about x, y and z" and, you know.

[00:40:15] Or even just being rushed out of the building. Once TC started closing their doors very, very quickly and sometimes folks would be like, "oh, you know, they're a little bit heavy handed or like rude when they're pushing you out" and stuff like that. I'm like – because I had those communications and relationships with the staff members, I understood that they were just doing their job the same as you or I are paid to do.

[00:40:47] And so understanding and displaying that understanding goes a long way in how people perceive you. And so just kind of how I was raised to be respectful and raised to kind of communicate and take the time to talk to folks at various levels. It came very much in handy in terms of learning more about other people's lives, learning more about my own interests through talking to others, and then also seeing future kind of opportunities that would open up for me.

[00:41:24] The fact that I had a great relationship with Corbin, Dr. Campbell, the fact that I had a great relationship with Noah, you know, Dr. Drezner, those things came into play when it came down to me understanding what the next step was for me and being interested in the Ph.D. process. And so them being able to kind of help me think through what would be a good fit for me. Not just in terms of place but also program.

[00:41:49] What would get at what I was interested in exploring. And similarly with other students. Like Ty was a huge, huge – Ty and Chase were like huge helps when it came to just me understanding the Ph.D. process, how to navigate that. They were so open, so honest and so willing and ready to help.

[00:42:12] I sent them my personal statement to look over. They gave me feedback on it. Especially Ty. He sent – he and Chase sent their CV's so I could get an understanding of what a CV looked like. A good one. And then they sent their personal statements so I could understand how to start crafting my own narrative and why that's important and how to back those things up with research.

[00:42:40] And so my interpersonal nature and inclination became that strength because it allowed me to gain all of these facets of knowledge and

experience through other people who would then go on to kind of help me to step into doors that were opening.

Tobar: I think you allude to this very well in this previous question. But this next one is more about like if you had any struggles or obstacles that you confronted while you were at TC and how were you able to overcome them? Can you recall any other examples that haven't been mentioned?

Ogwo: [00:43:22] I think one of the main things with TC – one of the main obstacles might have been just financial. But that was – that's a part of being in grad school. Unfortunately, there are limited opportunities for funding through the institution that are available to you and then that – it was exacerbated by the fact that you are at a private institution like TC.

[00:43:53] Those funding hazards or concerns that I had could have been a big – those I more so kept to myself just by virtue of the type of person that I am and how I talk about finances. So those were things that I was more so dealing with personally and familial – family-wise.

[00:44:28] I think that that was what it was. My takeaway from that was more so just going back to the importance of having – these institutions having built-in financial supports for their students even at the graduate level. Because it's very important. So I think that within a lot of literature and things like that you don't really talk about the financial needs of grad students.

[00:44:59] It was something that I think going through those hardships or times which I need to make sure that I'm paying for this institution, I have enough money for the institution, as well as my livelihood, that was something that reinforced later on and even now, just understanding that there needs to be more institutional avenues for grad students at all levels to be supported, just as far as there are for undergrads to be supported.

[00:45:33] And so I think it very much kind of helped to keep my eye on the prize of making sure that folks – all students across all levels had the tools and resources they needed to succeed and did not have to worry about things like finances or how they were going to fund their education.

[00:45:56] Aside from that, I think, again, the biggest problem was probably toward the end in which I was thinking through my doctoral journey. And so I was just very nervous about that process. And because I didn't know anyone within my family who had achieved a terminal degree, you know, a Ph.D., an MD, or whatever within my immediate family, I just – I didn't know what that process looked like.

[00:46:33] So hearing from other folks who, you know, would – maybe not consciously but kind of just emphasize the fact that in order to get into a Ph.D. program, you need to be stellar. You have to know what you want and have experience. And so for me coming out of my – straight from my

master's program, I got to a point in which I was scared. Like do I even just want to go straight in? Do I want to take time off to work?

[00:47:06] But if I do, what would I want to work in? And so understanding that like I didn't really want to work. I did want to go straight in. And so what that looked like for me. A lot of that was just kind of like personal thoughts and insecurities and things like that. Yeah, I think that for me – having the support of other people who found me, who re-emphasized the fact that, no, you need to do – you need to do this.

[00:47:40] And you have a voice and you have – I believe it was Dr. Sealey-Ruiz who literally said to me and that was the first time I really sat and just kind of believed it. She said that “you have a way with words that people need to hear and understand and be exposed to. And you would be doing a disservice to them and yourself if you kept that inside.”

[00:48:08] That, for me, I kind of leaned on that aspect of my identity, as well as spiritual identity when it came to kind of those insecurities and feeling like, “OK, am I good enough to go to the next level?” And so for me it was a lot of kind of making sure that those insecurities didn't stop me – again, like that stubbornness, that determination, – didn't stop me from, those insecurities didn't stop me from achieving what I wanted to achieve.

Tobar: How has the higher education experience at TC helped to shape your identity?

Ogwo: [00:48:53] I think that 1) it's made me more aware of research. But also made me more aware of the importance of self. And I think that had I not had faculty who were very open, honest, understanding about the fact that – and really meant it – that “life happens, and we understand that. And if something happens, like please, please let us know how we can help. Keep us in the loop so that, you know, at the end of the day these things don't come back to bite you.

[00:49:33] If something is going on and it's impacting your ability to work, please let us know.” And so having that prioritization of self, or the ability to be fully honest about things that were going on – just having that opportunity and the space to do so with our faculty was something that I very much appreciated.

[00:50:02] Did I always take advantage of that when I should have? No. But the fact that it was there very much influenced how I operated and continue to operate, now. And so I'm a big proponent of being open and honest with faculty and if you have the opportunity to be in a space in which your faculty understand that you're a person, first, I'm the first one to be like, “look, if you need an extension, you need to ask for it. If you need extra time, you need to ask for it and be honest about it.

[00:50:34] If you need to take a mental health day, you need to be honest with yourself about that.” And so I think a lot of that came from the openness with which my faculty at TC, within HPSE, kind of received me. And so how they really lived their lives kind of was mirrored in their teaching style. That, for me, was a huge kind of motivator for the type of – not just teacher, instructor – but person that I wanted to be.

[00:51:08] Especially within these academic spaces, that can be very draining. So understanding that sometimes you need to take a mental break and sometimes you need to step away in order to come back refreshed. And so I definitely owe that to – owe that part of my identity and exploration of my identity to my time within HPSE.

Tobar: How has working in BLMHE efforts changed the way you engage in activism and your local community?

Ogwo: [00:51:42] I think it goes back to my earlier point of understanding that activism takes different forms and not all of them have to be at a physical protest. I think, especially now within the time of COVID, how to be or consider oneself an activist and do activism work has had to look different.

[00:52:15] I think it’s influenced my understanding of how I approach these spaces that I’m in, what I want to get out of these spaces. And then also just kind of my radical belief that these spaces are going to use you – particularly, if you are a black person within this space – they are going to use you for diversity and you need to use them for everything that they’re willing to give you.

[00:52:39] And that is a form of radicalism that, you know, radical reciprocity. Because that is something that you are owed for contributing to the spaces. And so if they’re willing to offer you resources, funding, whatever, you need to take that. That, for me, is a form of activism. It’s a form of reclaiming the time, the energy that folks claim or perceive that they’re investing in you and using that to help or better the communities that you are interested in working with.

[00:53:14] And so that, for me, has been – I’ve been very mindful of how I can utilize school resources, or just resources that are offered or opportunities that are offered throughout the university that I’m at currently to do the work that I want to do. To understand more or learn more about the populations that I’m interested in.

[00:53:44] Yeah, so, I think that in that way, being in BLMHE very much helped for me to understand that activism can take many different forms. And so you can express those thoughts within research, within writing, but also can express them verbally, socially, within conversation. Because whether you’re on the frontlines or writing within research, the work never stops.

[00:54:16] And so you have to understand that you are constantly within this state of fighting against this oppressive system, whether it's actively or passively. And so I think that being in BLMHE helped me to understand that even those times in which I dared to speak up or speak out against something that I find wrong or incorrect or problematic that folks are saying in a class or in a space – not even just class, a social space – I have no qualms calling that out.

[00:54:52] And so part of that is understanding that I'm stopping the perpetuation of a narrative that can continue going on, even if it's just this one person. Even if it doesn't change their mind, they know not to say around me. And so that also is a form of activism. Because if you're not walking the walk that you're saying you do, people can pick up on that.

[00:55:19] And so I'm not just about writing about it, you know, or just going to a protest and then saying I'm an activist. I'm about being that person who is going to – if you have a problematic opinion, you know not to come to me with it. And so that's something that I think being an activist is. Is being so firm and grounded in your beliefs and your ways of knowing and acting and believing that other folks either gravitate towards you because they agree or gravitate away from you because they don't agree.

[00:55:54] Whether you're doing that through your writing or your research or conferences or conversations with people, or you're doing it at protests or sit-ins or what have you, or even politically, you are still making sure that your voice is heard and people understand where you're coming from. And so that is something that I find that's unshakeable that activism is for me now, and it very much influences how I approach the activism that I do, how I see what activism is within the communities I occupy, now.

Tobar: What are your thoughts on how students movements continue to inform and influence culture and politics as we continue to fight racial inequality in higher education.

Ogwo: [00:56:46] Oh, I mean, student movements are very powerful. I think that people sometimes underestimate the power of students because they think that students live in a bubble or don't understand fully what's going on with the world. I have to push back on that because college – and it very much depends on what college you go to and what the demographics of the college, but also the space, the geographic location of that college is – but it [college] exposes you to different people.

[00:57:23] And it exposes you to different understandings, ways of life, ways of knowing that some of them are going to be uncomfortable and some of them are going to like bump against what it is that you know and understand and were brought up to think. And so when folks think about this bubble, they're not necessarily thinking about the differences that happen or occur or disagreements that occur within those bubbles.

[00:57:54] Understanding that students are riled up and they're ready to go and have these conversations. Sometimes students feel, you know, in a better position to act on some of these things that – these injustices that they're noticing. Sometimes they're more ready to act than the faculty, the staff, the political leaders that are saying that they care about these issues.

[00:58:21] Students they are saying, you know, "I have stake in the matter, too, and I'm not afraid to use my voice and leverage my voice to get what I want." And so I think that that's something that folks continue to underestimate is students' abilities to mobilize. One example is currently – and this is something that is ongoing and so I won't mention too much about it.

[00:58:48] There was a student who at the institution I'm at now, he was suspended for responding physically to a white student who called him the "n" word. This didn't happen on campus. It happened off-campus. But the guidelines of the university they say it doesn't matter.

[00:59:15] The student was suspended for two years and the student was nearing graduation. And so if it was not for the mobilization of that student, as well as other students in saying, "Look, I know that this – this isn't ideal and maybe I should not have responded how I did, but two years is a long time, especially I would like to finish my education."

[00:59:46] So putting a petition out there, having folks sign it, folks spreading the word about the situation, folks like literally telling – you know, be like, "This is wrong." Students who are saying, "Hey, we've been called into a meeting to talk about this. What are some things that you want to bring up as a black student on this campus?" Just all these different facets were moving literally within the same day.

[01:00:16] And so what ended up happening was that through these students calling out and calling to task the university, they had to at least hear this student out. And so he was able to get a hearing with key players in terms of administration. And so that is the process in which they are embroiled now.

[01:00:42] But the fact that he was even able to get a seat at the table because of the activism and the movement and mobilization of students, it speaks to, again, what we're all about. I can go back to even when "being black at," that hashtag that happened some years ago. This was back when I was an undergrad.

[01:01:13] It started – I don't know if I would say it started but essentially what started at the University of Michigan and talking about being black at the University of Michigan, that hashtag literally blew up. And then next thing you know institutions were having to call in students because they were getting lambasted on these social media platforms and they didn't like it.

[01:01:34] And so then students started having demands, students started organizing. So it was just – students have a lot of power and institutions are sometimes very much afraid of that. But the thing is that students need to understand that they have power and that's where the issue comes. Because a lot of times these institutions they'll make you feel like you're just a number, just a speck in the whole painting.

[01:02:04] And so you have to understand that you as a student have the ability to mobilize against something that you see as wrong or unjust. So, yeah, I think that within the larger political context, societal context, it's nothing new. This has been happening since the Civil Rights Era and even before then when students were advocating for black students to be allowed on university campuses. For black students to live and exist on university campuses.

[01:02:37] For them to not be hassled by, threatened by, followed by university officials, police, being beaten. Like risks to their physical, their mental, emotional safety, their spatial safety. And so all these different – they're not new. Student activism is not a new thing. It's not just a current thing. It's always been and it's always had a very national and sometimes global following and understanding that students mean business.

[01:03:11] And I don't think that it's something that is talked about enough that even during the movements for BAMN: By Any Means Necessary. These movements that started on college campuses, the government was listening to these students. They found these students to be a national threat. People aren't talking about that. They saw these students, you know, who are supposed to be like, "oh, they're just focused on school and they're in their little bubble."

[01:03:44] They classified them as a national threat to the foundation of this country. And so that is something to understand. That students have a power that's literally feared. So yeah, I think that student activism has a lot of ability to change politics and society as we know it. And not just within America. We saw it with the Rhodes statues that came down in South Africa and just students were mobilizing to get those statues taken down.

[01:04:21] So student activism is nothing to be taken lightly and I think that it has a lot of power and a lot of weight within the political movements and within larger society.

Tobar: At the end of the day how would you characterize the impact of all this work on your own life and in your own thinking?

Ogwo: [01:04:49] How would I characterize it. I think I would characterize it as important, necessary, empowering, reinvigorating. Because it reminds me of the importance of the work that we have to do. The work is never done. I think that sometimes you can get bogged down in the fact that a lot of the issues that we're facing within this country, particularly as minoritized

individuals, and for me as a black person, as a black woman within this country, getting bogged down in the fact that a lot of the oppressions and barriers that I face are systemic. And so having these outlets, whatever those are for activism, to be a part of something even as a student is very much that reminder that I need that even if I cannot change this whole entire system by myself, I can change the aspects of it that I disagree with within my own space.

[01:05:58] And so making sure that I am holding the spaces that I'm in accountable and making sure I'm doing what I need to do in order to ensure that the generations that come after me of black scholars, of black students, are able to leave higher education as a better space than it was when they came in. And so that continues to be my goal, my journey, my mission, as a person within higher education and as a black person within higher education, I need to make this space better for those who come after me.

[01:06:37] I was just having this conversation for a research piece that my friends or colleagues and I are doing. I'm all for the promotion of those who are coming after us. I don't want to just leave this space having gotten what I've gotten and that's it. I very much believe in bringing up the next generation, two generations, three generations of black women scholars who are also going to be fighting for the same exact things that I'm fighting for. Or different things that still contribute to the movement.

[01:07:13] And so all of these kind of various forms of activism, whether it's through research, whether it's through literature, poetry, short stories, spoken word, art, public speech. Whether it's through politics. Whether it's through protests or sit-ins or whatever have you, making sure that folks are heard and making sure that their voices are amplified, their stories matter to the larger tapestry of this country.

[01:07:51] That is what I feel when I think about the activism of not just students but just of the state that we are in. And so that for me was very helpful. BLMHE helped to build that up as a foundation and so that foundation I have used to continue building with others and for others and alongside others. So, yeah.

Tobar: Thank you. I think we're done. Do you have any final words to share before we wrap up?

Ogwo: [01:08:33] Just that I'm very grateful to be a part of – or have been a part of Black Lives Matter in Higher Education. I continue to talk about it and people continue to recognize what it means and what it stands for, even within the spaces that I'm in today. I remember another student having a BLMHE shirt. I remember just having a conversation with him afterwards and him talking about, "Oh, my gosh, you're a part of Black Lives Matter in Higher Education?" I love everything they stand for and you all do.

[01:09:12] So it was just having those opportunities to share with folks what this mission really means. Like not just Black Lives Matter in Higher Education as, you know, something that's written, but something that's embodied. And so being able to kind of exemplify that in my actions and what I do in the spaces I occupy and what I do with those spaces has been something that I would not have gotten a chance to do had I not been a part of this organization.

[01:09:46] So for the organization, I'm very grateful. For the people who made it what it was, I am very grateful. And for even our own contributions, my own contribution, alongside my colleagues, in making it what it was and is today, I'm especially grateful for having that opportunity. And I'm appreciative of you for taking the time to document what that movement was and has been and continues to be for Black Lives Matter in Higher Education.

Tobar: Thank you so very much, Ashley.

Ogwo: [01:10:20] Absolutely. You're very welcome.

[End of recording 01:10:45]